

*Change of Command
Center for Naval
Aviation Technical
Training Unit, Oceana*



*Naval Air Station Oceana
Virginia Beach, Virginia*

17 April 2026



CNATTU OCEANA

MISSION

To provide specialized and advanced technical training to aviation maintenance personnel on F/A-18A-F and EA-18G aircraft weapons systems, related aircraft systems, Intermediate Level Maintenance, Department of the Navy weapons, and Foreign Armed Systems, producing qualified Fleet-ready Sailors and Marines capable of sustaining combat aviation capability and to perform additional functions and tasks as directed by higher authority.

VISION

To create an efficient and dynamic learning environment that enables students to take full advantage of their potential as professional Aviation Maintenance Technicians; capable of having a substantial impact on their unit's mission readiness.

The Tradition of the Change of Command Ceremony

Naval ceremonies predate the Christian era. Common dangers and shared victories tend to the creation of brotherhood, and in none is it closer than that of the naval profession where men and women are bound by common traditions, shared practices and ancient customs. The Navy, an organization of explicit discipline, lends itself to the perpetuation of the more venerable customs, heroic traditions, and dignified ceremonies such as that which we are witnessing today.

The ceremonies, customs, and traditions of today's Navy draw their origin from ancient customs and laws of the sea, which gradually evolved into the British Naval Regulations in force at the time of the American Revolution. The effect these old customs have had in the formulation of naval regulations is a marked example of the influence of tested usage.

John Adams, who compiled the first rules for regulation of the Navy in the United Colonies, and thus set a precedent for future provisions, used as his guide the instructions and regulations of the British Admiralty, themselves a product of time-honored traditions and custom. It was under the direction of these that the Father of the U.S. Navy, John Paul Jones, gave our Navy its earliest traditions of heroism and victory.

The Change of Command ceremony witnessed today is not prescribed specifically by U.S. Navy Regulations, but rather is an honored product of our rich heritage of naval tradition. It is a custom unique to the Navy, without equal in the Armed Forces. Custom has established the ceremony be formal and impressive - designed to strengthen the respect for the authority vital to any military organization. Parading all hands at quarters and public reading of official orders stem from those days when movement of mail and persons was a very slow process. This procedure was designed to ensure that only authorized officers held command and that all aboard were aware of its authenticity.

At the heart of the ceremony is the formal reading of official orders by the relieving officer and the officer to be relieved. Command passes upon utterance by the relieving officer, "I relieve you, sir!" The officer being relieved responds, "I stand relieved!" This simple procedure is duplicated hundreds of times daily throughout the navies of the world as Watch Officer passes responsibility to their reliefs in the conduct of ship and command routine.

"Side Boys"

In the days of said, it was not uncommon for the Commanding Officer of ships sailing in convoy to convene aboard the flagship for conferences or special meals. Unfortunately, there was no easy way to bring visitors on and off a ship while underway. Often, the boatswain's chair, a rope and wood sling, would be used to hoist the guest onto and off the ship. The number of "strong backs" or "side boys" required was dependent upon the size of the load being hoisted. Sailors soon noted that the more senior the visitor's rank, the more side boys needed to hoist the load. Over time, the need to hoist visitors onto and off Navy ships went away, but the custom of mustering side boys to honor the arrival and departure of distinguished guests remained, with more senior Officers honored by the presence of additional side boys.

"Piping"

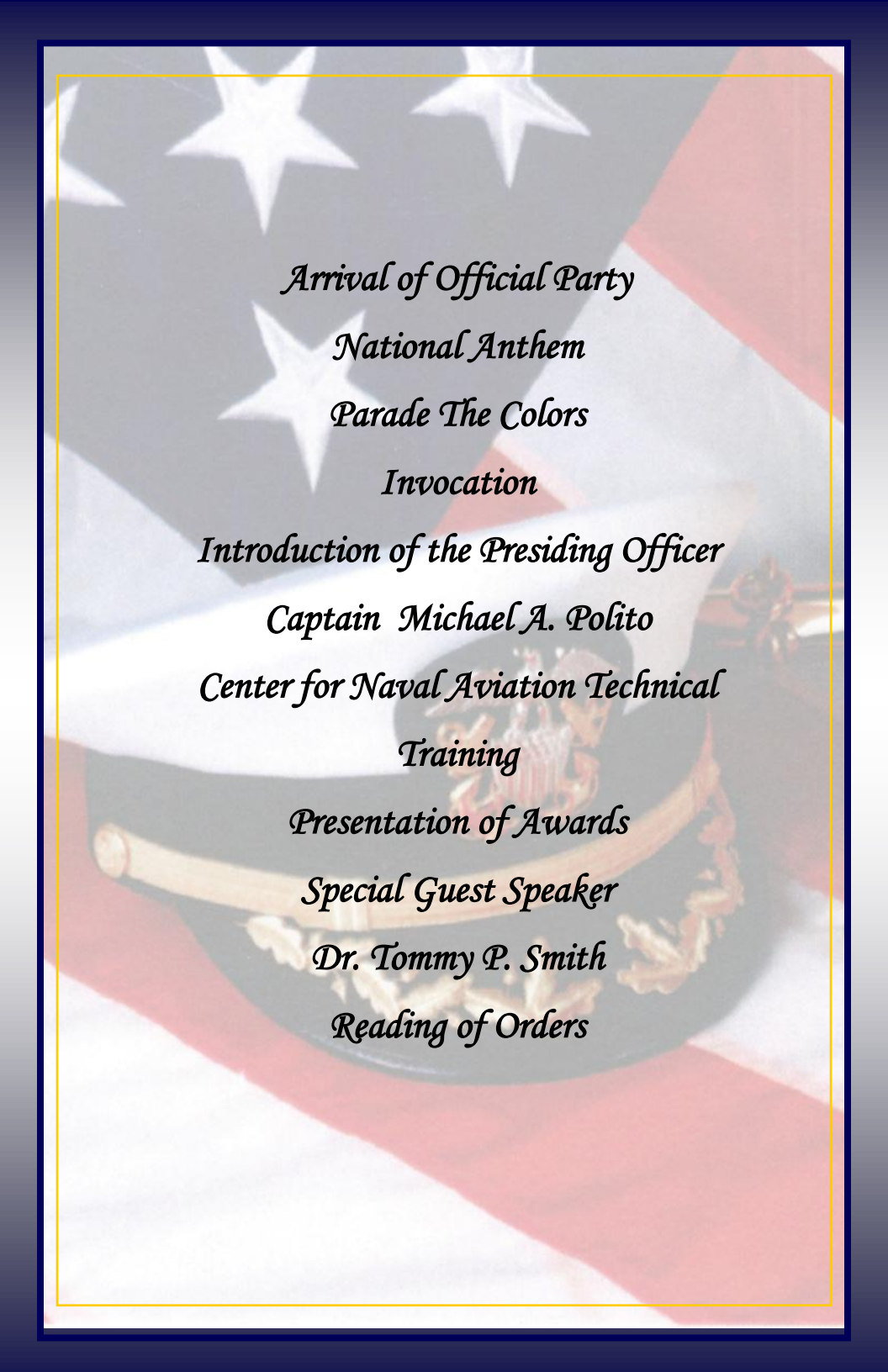
Boatswains have been in charge of the deck force since the days of sail. Setting sails, heaving lines, and hoisting anchors required great teamwork, and boatswains used whistle signals from the "boatswain's pipe" to coordinate the effort. When visitors were hoisted aboard or over the side, the pipe was used to order "Hoist Away" or "Avast Heaving." As with side boys, over time piping became an honored tradition to recognize distinguished guests both at sea and shore.

The strength of today's Navy stems in large measure from the observance of customs and traditions, each founded on need, each contributing it's share to stability, combat effectiveness, and smooth transfer of authority. This simple ceremony - passing authority and responsibility to another officer - reflects the dedication of free citizens serving their nation proudly.



Schedule of Events

17 April 2026



Arrival of Official Party

National Anthem

Parade The Colors

Invocation

Introduction of the Presiding Officer

Captain Michael A. Polito

Center for Naval Aviation Technical

Training

Presentation of Awards

Special Guest Speaker

Dr. Tommy P. Smith

Reading of Orders

Captain Michael A. Polito

Commander

Center For Naval Aviation Technical Training



Capt. Michael A. Polito, a native of Long Island, New York, enlisted in the U.S. Navy in 1985 and earned his commission in 2001 through Officer Candidate School. He graduated from Naval Post Graduate School in 2018 with a master's degree in system analysis and in 2006 with a Master of Business Administration; Chapman University in 2002 with a Master of Arts in Organizational Leadership; Southern Illinois University in 1999 with a Bachelor of Science in Education; and Vincennes University in 1997 with an Associate of Arts.

His operational assignments include quality assurance officer (QAO), material control officer (MCO) and aviation maintenance officer (AMO) at Electronic Attack Squadron (VAQ) 134; IM-4, IM-2 then IM-3 division officer aboard USS Abraham Lincoln (CVN 74); AMO and maintenance material control officer (MMCO) at Fleet Air Reconnaissance Squadron (VQ) 2; and AMO and MMCO aboard USS John C. Stennis (CVN 74). Ashore, he served as maintenance training officer and legal officer at Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training Unit (CNATTU) Whidbey Island; 600 division officer, maintenance officer (MO) and executive officer at Fleet Readiness Center Northwest; lead aviation readiness analyst in the force generation branch of OPNAV N81 supporting the Chief of Naval Operations in future year defense planning with independent analytical assessments of Navy and Marine Corps flying hour program, aircraft and engine depot maintenance, aviation logistics and air systems support accounts worth over \$11 billion; officer in charge at Fleet Readiness Center Southeast; AMDO community detailer at Naval Personnel Command; and N43 director of current readiness at U.S. Fleet Forces Command. He reported to Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training as deputy commander in November 2023.

He began serving as CNATT commander in November 2025. His personal awards include the Meritorious Service Medal (three awards), Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medal (seven awards) and Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal (three awards).

Commander Alexa Striba
Commanding Officer
Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training
Unit, Oceana



Commander Alexa Striba, a native of Manhattan, New York, enlisted in the U.S. Navy in 1991 and completed recruit training in Orlando, FL. She attended Aviation Ordnance "A" School at Naval Aviation Technical Training Center in Memphis, Tennessee. Her first assignment was with the Weapons Department at Naval Support Facility Diego Garcia, followed by a deployment with VP-10 to Puerto Rico supporting counter-drug operations in 1993.

In 1995, she joined VP-8, participating in Operations Sharp Guard and Decisive Endeavor from Naval Air Station Sigonella, Italy. She later transferred to Naval Air Technical Training Center Pensacola, Florida, where she earned her Master Training Specialist designation. In 2001, she reported to USS Theodore Roosevelt (CVN-71), deploying three times in support of Operations Southern Watch, Enduring Freedom, and Iraqi Freedom. In 2005, she was selected for Limited Duty Officer.

Commander Striba's officer assignments include serving as Ordnance Officer-in-Charge at Pohang, Republic of Korea, and Air Gunner aboard USS Theodore Roosevelt during a deployment supporting Operation Enduring Freedom. In 2009, she joined Strike Fighter Wing Atlantic as the Air Launch Weapons Team Gunner, where she was responsible for ordnance logistics for 17 Strike Fighter Squadrons.

In 2012, she returned to USS Theodore Roosevelt as Weapons Assembly Division Officer, leading 126 Sailors through critical milestones and the 2015 deployment. In 2017, she was selected as a leadership instructor at the Center for Personal and Professional Development, Dam Neck. She was later hand-picked to serve as the Weapons Division Head and command representative on the Weapons Systems Explosive Review Board at the Naval Safety Center in Norfolk, Virginia.

Promoted to Lieutenant Commander in 2017, she served as the Ordnance Handling Officer aboard USS Harry S. Truman (CVN-75) during the 2018-2019 deployments in support of maritime security operations. She was then appointed Force Ordnance Handling Officer for Commander, Naval Air Forces Atlantic, overseeing ordnance personnel across seven aircraft carriers and six type wings. She became the first female Force Ordnance Handling Officer and the third woman to reach the rank of Commander as an Aviation Ordnance Limited Duty Officer.

In 2022, Commander Striba volunteered as Department Head aboard USS George H.W. Bush (CVN-77), leading 280 Sailors through critical milestones and the 2022-23 deployment. Lastly, she served as the first female Commanding Officer at the Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training Unit Oceana.

Commander Striba's personal awards include the Meritorious Service Medal, Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medal, and Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal. She holds a Bachelor of Arts in Organizational Leadership from Ashford University and a Master of Executive Leadership from Liberty University.

Commander Richard S. Duchnowski
Executive Officer
Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training
Unit, Oceana



Commander Rich Duchnowski is a native of New Jersey. He is a 1994 graduate from Wayne Hills High School and upon graduation entered the U.S. Navy in February 1995 as an Aviation Electronics Technician. He holds an Associate of Arts Degree from Excelsior University and was commissioned in 2009 through the Limited Duty Officer program. His enlisted assignments included the Scorpions of VAQ-132 (EA-6B), CNATTU Pensacola where he served as an Avionics "A" school instructor, the Yellowjackets of VAQ-138 (EA-6B) where he was selected as "Sailor of the Year" and to the rank of Chief Petty Officer and served a short tour at CNATTU Whidbey Island as a "C" school instructor before commissioning in 2009.

As an officer, he served as IM4 DIVO, IM2 DIVO and QAO aboard the USS Abraham Lincoln. After completing that tour in 2012, he transferred to the Vikings of VAQ-129, the FRS for EA-6B and EA-18G where he earned the 2014 Lester B. Tucker award as the "Ground Officer of the Year". After completing 129, he took orders to the Patriots of VAQ-140 where he transitioned them from EA-6B Prowler to the EA-18G Growler and ultimately into combat operations. He served as MMCO and AMO during that tour. In 2017, he moved from Whidbey Island to the master Jet Base of Oceana, Virginia where he took on his 2nd FRS, the Gladiators of VFA-106. He served as the QAO and MMCO and transitioned them from the legacy Super Hornet (F/A-18 A-D) to the Super Hornet (F/A-18 E/F). During this tour, he also completed a 9-month TAD assignment to Commander, Naval Air Forces Atlantic (CNAL) where he served as Deputy MOC director. In 2020, he was selected as the Carrier Airwing THREE Maintenance Officer (CAGMO) for Team Battle Axe and completed a 5th fleet deployment aboard the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower leading the way for the withdrawal from Afghanistan. In 2022, he took orders to the Pro's Nest of VP-30, the P-8 FRS and served as the Maintenance Officer where his team won back-to-back Golden Wrench awards. In 2024, he transferred to CNATTU Oceana where he serves as the Executive Officer.

He has completed seven sea-going deployments across five aircraft carriers and two expeditionary deployments. His awards include the Meritorious Service Award (two awards), Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medal (six awards), Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal (four awards), and various unit and campaign awards. He is a qualified Professional Aviation Maintenance Officer. Commander Duchnowski is married to the former Kathryn Corbett from Southaven, MS for 30 years and they have two children, Lyndsay (26) and Cody (22).

Commander Douglas A. Kesterson
Perspective Executive Officer
Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training
Unit, Oceana



Commander Doug Kesterson, a native of San Antonio, Texas enlisted in the U.S. Navy in 1999 as an aviation ordnance technician and reported for duty to the VFA-83 "RAMPAGERS." During his tour, he completed two combat deployments to the Persian Gulf onboard the USS GEORGE WASHINGTON (CVN-73) and earned his Enlisted Aviation Warfare Specialist Designation.

In 2004, he attended Basic Instructor Training school at FTC Norfolk, Virginia and then checked in to the Strike Fighter Weapon School, Atlantic (SFWSLANT) as a Weapons Loading Instructor. During his time there he assisted seven squadrons in the successful transition from the F-14 "TOMCAT" to the F/A-18E/F "SUPER HORNET," and performed several Conventional Weapon Loading Proficiency Inspections (CWLPI) on Atlantic Fleet Squadrons.

In May of 2007, Cmdr. Kesterson was assigned to the VFA-131 "WILDCATS." He deployed with the USS GEORGE WASHINGTON (CVN-73) on a Partners of America cruise and made two deployments to the Fifth Fleet area of responsibility onboard the USS DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER (CVN-69) serving as the Ordnance LPO, the Line Division LPO, and a Quality Assurance Representative. In 2010, he was initiated as a Chief Petty Officer and served as a Maintenance Control Safe for Flight Representative, Phased Maintenance Coordinator, and Ordnance Leading Chief Petty Officer.

In October 2011, Cmdr. Kesterson was commissioned to the rank of Ensign and attended LDO/CWO indoctrination at Officer Training Command (OTC) Newport, Rhode Island.

In November 2011, he traveled to Bremerton, Washington and was assigned to the USS JOHN C. STENNIS (CVN-74) as the G-4 Division Officer and Weapons Elevator Officer. He also served as the G-5 Division Officer and Weapons Quality Assurance Officer and successfully completed two deployments to the Persian Gulf.

In August 2014, he traveled to Kaneohe Bay, Hawaii where he was assigned as the Marine Aircraft Group 24 Ordnance Department Head. During his tour, he orchestrated explosive operations for Marine Rotational Force-Darwin, MAG-24 squadrons, and provided I-level munitions and Aircraft Armament Systems maintenance for CPBW-2 squadrons. In 2015, he was honored by the Honolulu Navy League and awarded the Navy League Award for Excellence.

In October 2017, Cmdr. Kesterson reported to Carrier Air Wing TWO (CVW-2) as the Carrier Air Wing Weapons Officer. He completed an operational deployment to the Western Pacific, RIMPAC 2018, SUSTEX 2018, and Fleet Battle Problem 29. Additionally, he was the lead weapons integrator with Program Office/TYPE-WING/NAVAIR reps to capture requirements enabling the standup of the Navy's AIR WING OF THE FUTURE; the first CVW to incorporate F-35C. He shaped CVN-deck density solutions and was the lead voice in 5th generation weapons capabilities/gaps.

In August 2020, Cmdr. Kesterson reported to Commander, Strike Fighter Wing Pacific (CSFWP) as the Weapons Department Head where he was responsible for the training and readiness of F/A-18 aircraft assigned to CSFWP. Additionally, he managed \$579 million in Aircraft Armament Equipment and supported weapon systems in acquisition planning, assessing risk, and contract tracking.

In November 2021, Cmdr. Kesterson reported to the USS DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER (CVN-69) as the Ordnance Handling Officer where he led over 295 officers and Sailors through all aspects of ammunition stowage, handling, and assembly of conventional weapons and the maintenance and upkeep of assigned magazine sprinkler systems and elevators.

In April 2023, Cmdr. Kesterson was reassigned to the Bureau of Naval Personnel in Millington, Tennessee as a Personnel Assignments Officer.

Cmdr. Kesterson's professional qualifications include a Master's Degree in Organizational Leadership from Brandman University, a Bachelor's Degree in General Studies from Columbia College, a certified Master Training Specialist, and earned Lean Six Sigma Champion and Black Belt certifications through the Management and Strategy Institute.

His personal awards include the Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medal (6), the Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal (7), Navy Good Conduct Medal (3), and various service and campaign awards.

AOCM Devin J. Thompson

Senior Enlisted Leader

*Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training
Unit, Oceana*



Master Chief Aviation Ordnanceman Devin J. Thompson, a native of Vinita, Oklahoma, enlisted in the U.S. Navy and attended basic training in Great Lakes, Illinois in September 1998. Upon completion of recruit training, he attended ATD School in Chicago, Illinois, in December 1998.

In January 1999, he reported to the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower CVN-69 in Norfolk, VA. While there, he was assigned to the Weapons Department in the G-3 Division. While assigned to CVN-69 he deployed on the millennium cruise and took the ship into its half-life maintenance phase Reactor Complex Over haul. His subsequent sea duty assignments were USS Harry S. Truman VN-75, USS Theodore Roosevelt CVN-71, USS Harry S. Truman CVN-75 and USS John C. Stennis CVN-74. He also was assigned to two Individual Assignment tours on USS Pounce Afloat Forward Staging Base in Bahrain and Weapons Division Officer Camp Lemonnier in Djibouti.

Throughout his career, he completed deployments in Second, Fifth and Sixth Fleet areas of responsibilities and participated in operations Deliberate Forge, Iraqi Freedom, Enduring Freedom, Inherent Resolve, Spartan Kopsis and Dynamic Force Employment. His shore duty assignments include a tour at Oceana Weapons station in Virginia Beach, Virginia and Atlantic Training Command Norfolk OHSAT in Norfolk, Virginia. He reported to Center for Naval Aviation Technical Training Unit Oceana as the Senior Enlisted Leader in April 2026.

Master Chief Thompson's personal awards include the Enlisted Aviation Warfare, Enlisted Surface Warfare and Master Training Specialist; Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medal (Three Awards), Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal (Five Awards) and various unit and campaign awards.

Dr. Tommy P. Smith



Dr. Tommy P. Smith, affectionately known as TPS, exemplifies the enduring principles of Teacher, Preacher, and Servant three roles that define both his calling and his character. With humility, discipline, and unwavering faith, Dr. Smith serves as the Pastor of Divine Baptist Church in Chesapeake, Virginia, where his leadership continues to inspire spiritual growth and strengthen the broader community.

A native of Georgia, Dr. Smith relocated to Florida during his teenage years and began a distinguished career of service by enlisting in the United States Air Force in 1981. Over more than 24 years of honorable active-duty service, he demonstrated exceptional leadership, commitment, and professionalism. Following his military retirement, Dr. Smith continued shaping future leaders as an Aerospace Science Instructor with the Air Force Junior Reserve Officer Training Corps (AFJROTC). He served for 11 years at Indian River High School and currently serves at Western Branch High School, where he instructs and mentors students in leadership, character development, and management principles.

Dr. Smith is deeply committed to lifelong learning. His academic and professional training spans Instructor Technology, Military Science, Avionics Technology, Personnel Administration, Occupational Education, Organizational Leadership and Management. Dr. Smith earned his Doctor of Strategic Leadership degree from Regent University, reflecting his dedication to scholarly excellence, ethical leadership, and spiritual integrity.

As a preacher of the Gospel, Dr. Smith's ministry has reached audiences around the world. He has shared the message of Christ in diverse and challenging environments, including regions with limited religious freedom such as the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and Republic of Turkey, as well as numerous austere locations. Guided by Romans 2:11 "For there is no respect of persons with God"—his preaching transcends cultural, generational, and socio-economic boundaries, offering a message that is both relevant and transformative.

Answering God's call with a servant's heart, Dr. Smith lives out the words of Isaiah 6:8: "Here am I; send me." He is a proud Life Member of the Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Incorporated, and while his accomplishments are many, he considers his greatest honor to be serving the faithful members of Divine Baptist Church.

Dr. Smith is married to the former Brenda Peoples of Gainesville, Florida, and they are the proud parents of one daughter, Shannon, a United States Air Force veteran. Anchored in faith, Dr. Smith gives all glory to God and stands firmly on Ephesians 3:20, trusting in God's power to do "exceeding abundantly above all that we can ask or imagine."

*The ultimate mission of Dr. Tommy P. Smith is simple yet profound: to Impact the World. As the author of *Servant Leadership: A Paradoxical Truth*, his message continues to empower individuals globally to Teach, Preach, Serve, and Impact the World.*

CNATTU OCEANA

2025 OF THE YEAR AWARDEES

Senior Instructor of the Year (SIOY)

ADC(AW/SW) Genevieve m. Blackwell

Sailor of the Year (SOY)

AD1(AW) Deven R. Prince

Instructor of the Year (IOY)

AM1(AW) Brian J Hoffard

Marine of the Year (MOY)

SSGT Isaac J. Medeiros

Junior Instructor of the Year (JIOY)

AT2(AW) Robert L. Spitcaufsky

Junior Sailor of the Year (JSOY)

AD2(AW) Alicia D Ashley

Non-Commissioned Officer of the Year (NCOOY)

SGT Jeramil O. Agronsoto

Civilian of the Year (COY)

Mrs. Amanda D. Baylor

CNATTU OCEANA

FORMER COMMANDING OFFICERS

CDR Luther Kinsley

June 2000 – June 2002

CDR Stephen Johnson

June 2002 – May 2004

CDR Scott Abel

May 2004 – June 2006

CDR Timothy Hooyer

June 2006 – August 2007

CDR Michael Singleton

August 2007 – December 2008

CDR John Wood

December 2008 – June 2010

CDR Alan Dean

June 2010 – November 2011

CDR Gilbert Mucke

November 2011 – July 2013

CDR Richard Sherman

July 2013 – January 2015

CDR Jeffry Sandin

January 2015 – June 2016

CDR Richard Grove

June 2016 – November 2017

CDR David Moore

November 2017 – June 2019

CDR Gary Shelley

June 2019 – December 2020

CDR Anthony Barber

December 2020-June 2022

CDR Patrick Batiste

June 2022-June 2023

CDR Uries S. Anderson

June 2023-December 2024

Forged in Steel, Tempered in Command

*I was forged where steel meets fire. Where precision is survival.
Where one mistake is one too many.*

*I learned early that power must be respected. That strength
must be disciplined. That readiness is not loud, it is exact.*

As an Aviation Ordnanceman,

*I swore to handle the Fleet's firepower
With calm hands and steady judgment. To arm with precision.*

*To safeguard
without
compromise.*

*To ensure that
when called,*

the weapons would answer.

Today, as I pass the guidon,

I stand not

only as a Commanding Officer,

But as an Ordnanceman still.

For command

is not so different from ordnance.

It requires weight to be carried carefully.

It requires discipline over ego.

It requires courage measured, not reckless.

*I have guarded this command, as I once guarded every round and
every rack, With accountability, with vigilance, with pride.*

To the Staff of CNATTU Oceana: You were my responsibility.

*You were my standard. You were my charge. The steel may rest, the
fire may dim, But the Ordnanceman's oath remains:*

Protect the mission. Protect the Sailor, Marines and Civilians.

Never lower the standard.

Fair winds and following seas.

~ Ms. Priscilla R. Gamble

Precision Becomes Command

*I was trained to see what others cannot. To trace the fault.
To correct the signal, To restore what must not fail.*

*As an Aviation Electronics Technician,
I learned that systems do not repair themselves.*

They require patience.

They require precision.

They require ownership.

You do not guess at solutions.

You diagnose.

You measure.

You test.

You verify.

And you stand behind your work,

Today, I take command

With the same oath I carried to the flight line:

If something is broken, I will fix it.

If something is weak, I will strengthen it.

If something can be better,

*I
will improve it.*

A command, like any system,

Depends on alignment.

On trust. On clear signals.

I will lead with clarity. I will act with integrity.

I will safeguard the mission and the Sailors entrusted to me.

The technician becomes the captain of the system.

And this system, this command,

Will operate at its highest standard.

The watch is mine now.

And I will keep it.

~ Ms. Priscilla R. Gamble

*Thank you for being a
part of our family.*



*Naval Air Station Oceana
Virginia Beach, Virginia*

17 April 2026